GRAND-CHUKUCHUKU

Chapter One pilot — “The Courtyard Keeps Score”

Runtime: 5:00 exactly

Format: Vertical 9:16, adult 2D animation; English and Cameroon Pidgin with English subtitles

Chapter placement: Chapter One / Fiango opening pilot

Story function: Introduce Zino, Gideon, Luc, the compound, Grand-Chukuchuku and the money pressure that will shape the chapter.

Fact boundary

- **C — Confirmed:** Fiango compound with a central mango tree and well; Zino meets Gideon and Luc through street football; mother is a primary-school teacher; the landlord collects rent and light money; Zino saved lunch money to play Nacking Bottle; the game uses two bottles and three hits wins; Zino was sent away from school in primary school because fees were unpaid.
- **P — Proposed:** This particular match, the fee notice, the landlord visit, all dialogue, the order of the events and the exact amount of money. They are designed for drama, not presented as a literal record.

Pilot promise

In one afternoon, a clever ten-year-old turns a missed football shot into an impossible legend. By night, the same small coins that could make him a street-football winner point to the bill that may put him outside school. The audience leaves wanting to know whether intelligence and charm can protect him from a problem neither can solve.

Timed shooting script

0:00–0:08 — COLD OPEN: THE BALL

VISUAL | P: An old football spins through amber dust toward two slippers marking a goal on a Fiango road. We hear boys shouting before we see them.

ZINO (O.S., P): Before you say na no goal, hear the whole story!

SOUND: Ball thump. Bucket rope creaks. A distant radio carries highlife guitar.

0:08–0:21 — THE COMPOUND

VISUAL | C setting / P action: Pull wide to the circular courtyard: mango tree, masonry well, laundry, close-set low houses. Ten-year-old ZINO tracks the ball; GIDEON keeps score with a coin; LUC has a small Bible tucked into his waistband.

GIDEON (P): One-one. Last chance, Zino.

LUC (P): Make we play fair.

ZINO (P): Fair? I invent fair.

0:21–0:40 — THE MISS

VISUAL | P: Zino feints Gideon, shoots hard and brushes the outside slipper. The ball rolls into a wash basin. Gideon immediately points outside the posts; Luc confirms it, reluctantly.

GIDEON (P): Outside. No goal.

ZINO (P): Your eye don miss road since morning.

LUC (P): Na outside, my brother.

0:40–0:58 — THE FIRST LEGEND

VISUAL | P fantasy: Younger children gather. Zino notices the audience and changes the defeat into theatre. A low roof becomes a stadium ledge. GRAND-CHUKUCHUKU, adult, immaculate in navy, appears above it. He does not fly; he calmly opens his hand and the ball curves through gold light around the mango tree.

ZINO (P): Grand-Chukuchuku score from worse side. Goalkeeper beg am: “Leave moon for sky!”

GIDEON (O.S., P): Your moon don enter Mama washing!

0:58–1:18 — BACK TO EARTH

VISUAL | P: The fantasy snaps off. The real ball sits in a plastic basin. Zino lifts it out, embarrassed but smiling. His MOTHER crosses the court in a teacher’s dress, carrying marked exercise books.

MOTHER (P): Zino. Basin first. Football later.

ZINO (P): Yes, Ma.

MOTHER (P): And later fit become never if you spoil my water.

1:18–1:38 — WELL WATER

VISUAL | C setting / P action: At the well, Zino rushes the rope and splashes water down his shirt. Gideon quietly pockets the scoring coin; Luc passes a bucket to an older neighbour. Zino tries again, slower, and fills the bucket cleanly.

GIDEON (P): Champion striker, rope don beat you.

ZINO (P): Grand-Chukuchuku pull river with one hand.

LUC (P): Then use two for this bucket.

1:38–1:58 — THE PRICE IN THE COURTYARD

VISUAL | C setting / P action: A LANDLORD moves from doorway to doorway with a worn notebook. The compound goes quiet in a way football never does. He speaks softly to Zino’s mother; we do not hear an amount. Mother nods once, more composed than relieved.

LANDLORD (P, low): Rent and light matter, Madam.

MOTHER (P): I hear you.

VISUAL | P: Zino watches from the well. The bucket rope squeaks in his hand.

1:58–2:16 — A SMALL PLAN

VISUAL | P: Mother puts a wrapped lunch and a few coins into Zino’s school bag for the next day. Zino sees older boys further down the road placing coins onto a folded cloth beside two empty bottles.

MOTHER (P): Tomorrow, chop before class. Your head needs food.

ZINO (P): My head get plenty food already.

MOTHER (P): Your head is not your stomach.

2:16–2:38 — SCHOOL MORNING

VISUAL | P: At day school, the lunch bell releases the courtyard. Zino watches his classmates queue for food, then folds the coins inside an exercise-book page. Gideon catches the movement. Luc closes his

small Bible and studies Zino’s face.

GIDEON (P): You no chop?

ZINO (P): I dey save strength.

LUC (P): Hunger no be strength.

2:38–3:00 — THE ANSWER

VISUAL | P: A teacher calls on Zino. He stands too fast. The folded money slips from his book, but he catches it before it falls. He answers the question cleanly. The teacher gives a brief approving look. Gideon sees the contrast: brilliant answer, empty stomach.

TEACHER (P): Correct. Sit down.

ZINO (P, under his breath): Even money like learn.

3:00–3:18 — THE OFFER

VISUAL | P: Outside school, an older player places two battered bottles at opposite ends of the red-earth strip. Slippers lie beside one end. A cloth holds the small pooled stakes.

ON-SCREEN SUBTITLE | C: *NACKING BOTTLE: HIT THE OTHER BOTTLE THREE TIMES.*

OLDER PLAYER (P): Everybody put something. Winner carry am.

GIDEON (P): You sure say your lunch money want play?

ZINO (P): My lunch money get ambition.

3:18–3:37 — FIRST HIT

VISUAL | C game / P action: Zino makes a quick feint and clips the opposing bottle. Glass clinks; the bottle falls. One finger rises. Gideon cannot help grinning. Luc claps once, then remembers himself.

CROWD (P): One!

GIDEON (P): I talk say your leg get market value.

ZINO (P): Market never close.

3:37–3:58 — THE TEST

VISUAL | P: The opponent returns a hard shot and knocks Zino’s bottle. One-all. Zino’s smile leaves. He looks from the coins to his friends, then to the setting sun. A faint gold outline of Grand-Chukuchuku appears beside the bottle—but the imagined man does not move for him.

LUC (P): No turn game to quarrel.

ZINO (P): I no dey quarrel. I dey negotiate.

3:58–4:16 — THE SHOT HE CANNOT BUY

VISUAL | P: Zino takes the ball, breathes, shoots. It misses wide. The opponent’s bottle stays standing. The older player collects the ball, not the money yet.

OLDER PLAYER (P): Two more. Play.

VISUAL | P: From the compound, Mother calls his name. It cuts through the street noise.

MOTHER (O.S., P): Zino!

4:16–4:34 — THE NOTE

VISUAL | P: Zino runs home with the ball under his arm. At the doorway, Mother holds a sealed school notice and her exercise books. Her face gives nothing away. Zino’s hand closes around the remaining coins in his pocket.

ZINO (P): Ma?

MOTHER (P): Come inside.

4:34–4:48 — THE QUESTION

VISUAL | P: In the doorway shadow, Mother turns the blank back of the notice toward him. The room is quiet except for the radio next door and a bucket filling at the well.

MOTHER (P): Tomorrow, tell your class master I am coming.

ZINO (P): For what?

MOTHER (P): You know for what.

4:48–5:00 — CLIFFHANGER

VISUAL | P: Close on Zino’s closed fist. He opens it: a few small coins. Their shine shifts into the gold curve of his fantasy football, then cuts to black before it reaches a goal.

ZINO (V.O., P): Grand-Chukuchuku always get one more chance.

END CARD: *GRAND-CHUKUCHUKU*

NEXT: *“Well Water”*

Performance and sound notes

- **Zino:** Quick, funny and defensive. The performance changes only twice: when he sees the landlord, and when he sees the school notice.
- **Gideon:** Notices money first, but never treats Zino’s hunger as a joke. His teasing carries affection.
- **Luc:** Fairness and faith make him the steady third point of the friendship triangle. His lines should be direct, not preachy.
- **Mother:** Never reduced to hardship. Her control, workload and care make the final line hurt because she does not need to shout.
- **Sound:** Layer well rope, football on packed dirt, bicycles, compound radio, cooking sounds, classroom chalk and evening insects. Let the soundtrack stop when the notice appears; leave only breathing, distant radio and water.

Continuity safeguards

1. The fee notice is a **proposed pilot device**. It represents the confirmed primary-school fee pressure without asserting an exact school, date, amount, wording or disciplinary outcome.
2. The football game uses bottles as targets; the children do not drink alcohol.
3. Grand-Chukuchuku is imaginary and appears only when Zino actively reshapes reality into a story. He cannot solve the real-world money problem.
4. The pilot sets up, but does not depict, Zino being sent away from school. That confirmed event needs Zino’s timing and fuller recollection before a later episode makes it literal.